Unless we are trying to make a point, or highlight a specific language feature, Ruby code is formatted to match the rules of the Standard gem.[1]

Command-line invocations are shown with literal text in a regular font, and parameters you supply are shown in an *italic* font. Optional elements are shown in brackets.

ruby ‹*flags*›* *progname* ‹*arguments*›*

Finally, in keeping with the style of previous editions of the book, I use the word *we* when referring to the authors collectively in the body of the book. Many of the words come from the first four editions, and I (Noel) don't want to claim any credit for Dave's, Andy's, and Chad Fowler's previous work. That said, opinions on recent Ruby features, even when prefaced by "we," are pretty much just my opinion, and are not an attempt to put words in the mouths of the previous authors.

Road Map

The main text of this book is divided into five parts, each with its own personality and each addressing different aspects of the Ruby language.

In *Part I, Facets of Ruby*, you'll find a Ruby tutorial. It starts with notes on getting Ruby running on your system followed by a short chapter on the terminology and concepts that are unique to Ruby. This initial chapter also includes enough basic syntax so that the other chapters will make sense. The rest of the tutorial is a top-down look at Ruby. There we talk about classes and objects, types, expressions, and all the other things that make up the language. We end with a chapter on unit testing.

One of the great things about Ruby is how well it integrates with its environment. *Part II, Ruby in Its Setting*, investigates this. Here you'll find practical information on using Ruby: using the interpreter options, using irb, documenting your Ruby code, type checking, and packaging your Ruby gems so that others can enjoy them.

Part III, Ruby Crystallized, contains more advanced material. Here you'll find all the details about using Ruby for the web, Ruby style, the concept of *duck typing*, the object model, metaprogramming, reflection, and object space. You could probably speed-read this the first time through, but we think you'll come back to it as you start to use Ruby in earnest.

Part IV, Ruby Language Reference, includes more complete notes on syntax and fuller documentation of language features discussed in the first three parts.

The *Ruby Library Reference* makes up Part V. It's not a complete reference to the entire Ruby library—that's much more readily available at https://docs.ruby-lang.org/en—but it is a map to the most commonly used and most useful features of the library.

So how should you read this book? Well, depending on your level of expertise with programming in general and object-oriented programming in particular, you may initially want to read just a few portions of the book. Here are our recommendations.

If you're a beginner, you may want to start with the tutorial material in Part I. Keep the library reference close at hand as you start to write programs. Get familiar with the basic classes such as `Array`, `Hash`, and `String`. As you become more comfortable in the environment, you may want to investigate some of the more advanced topics in Part III.

1. https://github.com/testdouble/standard